

the way out. The idea of paying for personal information management software, database services or word processing is pretty antiquated.

Q You've been in systems administration in previous work places, are an active documentation writer/contributor, and also maintain a few packages yourself. Can you explain a bit about each of these roles, and whether you'd rather call yourself a writer, a developer or a systems administrator?

Actually, I wasn't ever really a true systems administrator. I did some work that bordered on sys admin work, but really, I was more of a dabbler. That having been said, I did get to touch upon a lot of different technology areas, from scripting and clustering, to building customised kernels and distros. I also spent a lot of time documenting what I did for other people, and teaching them hands-on. So I think the term 'dabbler' is probably best—Jack of all trades and master of none!

Q How did you get associated with the Fedora Project?

I started with Slackware but used Red Hat Linux starting with 4.1, all the way up until Red Hat Linux 9 was released. I didn't watch project schedules that much or subscribe to a lot of lists, so I didn't know about the Fedora Project until the fall of 2003. I was delighted to have a chance to contribute back to a community that had helped me build my skills, knowledge and career. I decided to get involved with documentation because I wasn't really a software developer, but I was a decent writer.

Q What's your role as the Fedora Project Leader?

The Fedora Project Leader is much like the Fedora Project's CEO. Ultimately, I'm accountable for everything that happens in Fedora. Red Hat pays me to make sure that the Project continues to fulfil its mission as a research and development lab for both the company and the community, and that we are consistently moving forward in our mission to advance free and open source software worldwide.

Q Among Fedora Project contributors are those who are RH employees, and there are those who work as volunteers. How do you ensure there's minimal clash of interests? For example, what if there's a significant difference of opinion on the direction Fedora should be headed towards?

To minimise the chances of this happening, we have a well-defined governance structure. For example, we have a Fedora Engineering Steering Committee (FESCo) that is entirely community-elected and makes technical decisions on features, schedules, and is in charge of special-interest technical groups such as our packaging group. Having a central place for technical decision-making means that there's a regular venue where arguments can be heard from both sides whenever someone is suggesting a change, whether that person is a volunteer or a Red Hat employee. We're all members of the same community.

Just about every engineer in Red Hat works for some time in Fedora, since Fedora is the upstream for the Red Hat Enterprise Linux product. Part of my job, and the job of the Fedora Engineering Manager, Tom 'Spot' Callaway, is to make sure that work is coordinated between the internal Red Hat groups that work in Fedora and the external community. When decisions are made by the community, we make sure that the internal groups participate and are informed, and when there is something that the internal groups want to pursue, we make sure they are discussing those needs with the community. In general, it ends up being a pretty smooth interaction.

Q What is Fedora's vision? By whom or how is it set or defined?

The Project Leader sets the vision for Fedora, which goes hand-in-hand with our mission to advance free software worldwide. The FPL's vision is often about finding the next big challenge for our project to overcome, as a community. In the past, those challenges have included establishing governance, unifying the way we manage our software, and creating a leadership team for Fedora inside Red Hat. I've spent the last ten months turning my sights outward on two problems—making it easier for people to join our community, and enlarging that community to include all those who remix or reuse Fedora in various ways. Really, the vision can only be a reality if the community agrees it's worthwhile, and it's my job not just to identify that vision, but to enlist the community's help to realise it.

Q There are some distributions that don't really care about upstream, where the distro developers and maintainers want to push their patches first into the distros to make it stand out from the rest of the crowd. Fedora, I believe, has a strict policy of working with the upstream, and whatever feature sets are available in the final distro are completely in sync with the upstream. What's your take on this and why do you think upstream contribution is more important?

Upstream contribution benefits the entire FOSS community. It's how the open source development model works—it's about collaboration and constant code review and refinement. When a distribution changes behaviour in a way that goes against the upstream model, three things happen.

First, there's immediately an uneven user experience. Users who try out newer versions of the same software from the upstream find that the behaviour changes suddenly and without warning. They think this is either a regression or a mistake on their part, when in either case the difference has been caused by the distribution vendor.

Second, the workload on the maintainers of that distribution begins to multiply and, in some cases, increase exponentially. The further out of step with the upstream the distribution becomes, the more difficult it becomes to integrate the distribution-specific changes with new upstream releases as time goes on.